

Building Capacity for Community Employment: The Role and Importance of Individualized Supports

As state agencies and organizations have prioritized integrated employment over other options for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities, direct support staff sometimes have rushed to place someone in a job that may not be a good match for the person or the community business. The placement “counts” as a job in the community, but it may not last.

To be successful, a robust and sustainable job match must be made. These matches start with knowing the individual, what they like/don't like, what they need to succeed, and where their skills and talents can be appreciated. A strong partnership with community businesses will provide a foundation for seeking individual, integrated jobs that meet businesses' needs, as well as those of job seekers and their families.

Get to know the individual.

Identify interests and job skills.

- » Block out time in your weekly planner to get to know the person
- » Use a person-centered focus.
- » Use discovery and other tools to learn the job seeker's interests and skills.
- » Build a personal profile to narrow down the job seeker's interest.

Discover conditions for success.

You need to know the person to know what conditions must be met for success on the job. Figure out what their comfort levels are, what is and isn't doable, and what type of environment works best for them.

You should know...

- » What the person's comfort levels are in different situations
- » What type of environment works best
- » Which assumptions that you're making are accurate, and which are not, based on your observations of and conversations with the person

Learn, recognize, and understand.

- » Talk with the individual seeking employment.
- » With that person's permission, talk with family members and people in the individual's social networks.
- » Observe how the individual you are supporting engages with the community in different settings.
- » Practice reframing challenges or characteristics that may be viewed negatively. Discuss what it takes to be successful in certain jobs and environments, and learn to recognize how a challenge or characteristic may be an asset to a particular business or in a certain industry. For example, the intense focus that some people on the autism spectrum bring to their tasks is seen as a great asset by many technology companies.
- » Brainstorm ways to highlight what the individual is good at, and what they need to avoid.

Provide customer service to businesses.

Learn about local businesses through networking.

To support the individual, work as a team, assigning staff to specific roles based on skills and strengths. The goal is to negotiate with employers and identify jobs that fit a business's needs. Case managers may focus on advocacy and ensuring the individual's goals are addressed. Other team members may network with the community, drive the person-centered planning process, or manage employer engagement.

Network with community leaders and local businesses.

- » Request in-person meetings to deepen relationships.
- » Find out businesses' unmet needs or expansion ideas.

Present and negotiate for the person.

You're there to facilitate a match:

- » Present the individual based on what you have learned.
- » Use resumes, video, etc.
- » Build on relationships the team has established.

Provide ongoing supports to sustain success.

Facilitate job skill development and social interaction to maximize success and independence in the workplace.

- » Use a job coach if needed.
- » Be flexible in the methods used to orient the individual and train them on job tasks.
- » Share self-management techniques.
- » Consult with the new employee and employer to supplement typical job supports.
- » Connect with and encourage co-workers to build natural supports.

Following this guidance will lead you to better practices and more success.



State Employment Leadership Network

The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.



NASDDDS

www.selnhub.org